

IH01

Indus Valley Civilisation

About 2-3 questions a paper from Indian History's 10-12. Kalibangan alone has come up again and again - 2013 (river), 2021 (excavator), and inside statement sets. Learn the site table cold and you have banked the marks.

Our first city-dwellers. For the exam this chapter is almost pure matching - which site, which river, which district, which excavator, which one famous find. And because Kalibangan sits in Hanumangarh, RPSC treats this as half a Rajasthan chapter.

Indus / Harappan Civilisation

Big five sites

- Harappa - Ravi - Daya Ram Sahni 1921
- Mohenjodaro - Indus - R.D. Banerji 1922
- Kalibangan - Ghaggar - B.B. Lal & B.K. Thapar
- Lothal - Bhogavo - S.R. Rao
- Dholavira - Kutch - R.S. Bisht

Material life

- Copper, bronze, gold, silver, lead - NO iron
- Steatite seals, unicorn commonest
- Chert weights, binary below 16
- World's first cotton

Rajasthan angle

- Kalibangan, Hanumangarh district
- Ghaggar = Saraswati
- Earliest ploughed field
- Seven fire altars
- Camel bones, bangle factory

Belief & burial

- Mother goddess, Pashupati seal
- Pipal, humped bull, swastika
- Cemetery R-37 and H at Harappa
- No temple anywhere

Town planning

- Grid streets at right angles
- Citadel west, lower town east
- Bricks 4:2:1
- Covered drains, manholes, soak-pits

Decline theories

- Wheeler - Aryan invasion
- Marshall / Rao / Raikes - floods
- Gurdip Singh - aridity
- G.F. Dales - tectonic shift

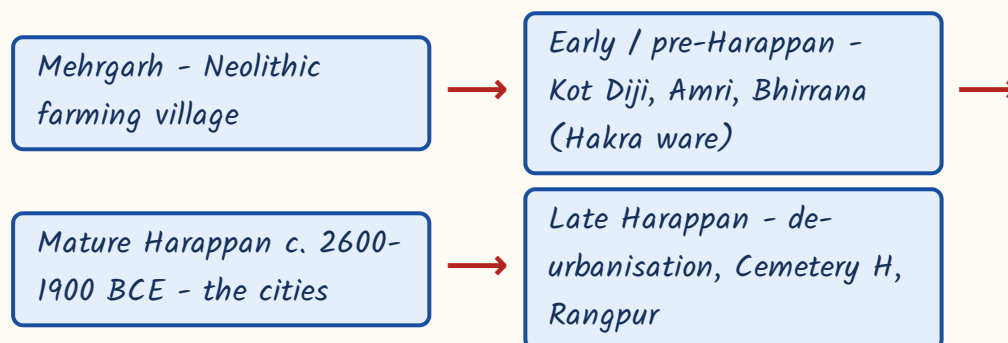
First fix the frame - who found it, when, and how big it was

Before 1921 Indian history textbooks began with the Vedas. Then two men digging in Punjab and Sindh pushed our past back by more than a thousand years. Daya Ram Sahni dug Harappa in 1921. R.D. Banerji reached Mohenjodaro in 1922. Both worked under John Marshall, then Director-General of the Archaeological Survey. The civilisation takes its name from Harappa because that is where the spade went in first.

Remember the naming logic - it is asked. It is called the Harappan civilisation after the first site excavated, and the Indus Valley civilisation after the river system. Neither name is wrong.

- Mature or urban phase: c. 2600-1900 BCE. The older ASI dating you will still see in books is 2500-1750 BCE.
- It is a Bronze Age civilisation - copper and bronze were known, iron was not.
- Roughly triangular in shape, and the largest in area of the four early river-valley civilisations.
- Mehrgarh near the Bolan pass in Balochistan is the Neolithic ancestor - earliest wheat and barley, and the earliest cotton in the subcontinent.
- Kot Diji (dug by Fazal Ahmed Khan) and Amri are early or pre-Harappan; Bhirrana in Fatehabad has the earliest Hakra-ware levels.

The cultural sequence - learn it as a ladder



YAAD RAKHO

Four boundary sites, four directions. Sutkagendor is West (Dasht river, Balochistan). Alamgirpur is East (Hindon, Meerut). Manda is North (Chenab, Jammu). Daimabad is South (Pravara, Maharashtra). Say it as W-E-N-S: Sutkagendor, Alamgirpur, Manda, Daimabad.

The site table - this is where the marks actually are

Nothing in this chapter pays like the site table. RPSC's favourite format is List-I sites against List-II rivers, or against excavators, or against one famous find. So learn each site as a four-part packet: river, district and state, excavator, and the one thing it is famous for. Do not learn paragraphs. Learn packets.

Site - river - location - excavator (learn all four columns)

Site	River	District / State	Excavated by
Harappa	Ravi	Montgomery (Sahiwal), Pakistan	Daya Ram Sahni, 1921
Mohenjodaro	Indus	Larkana, Sindh	R.D. Banerji, 1922
Kalibangan	Ghaggar (Saraswati)	Hanumangarh, Rajasthan	B.B. Lal and B.K. Thapar, 1961-69
Lothal	Bhogavo	Ahmedabad, Gujarat	S.R. Rao, 1955-62
Dholavira	Khadir Bet island	Kutch, Gujarat	R.S. Bisht, 1989-2005
Chanhudaro	Indus	Sindh, Pakistan	N.G. Majumdar 1931; Ernest Mackay 1935-36
Banawali	Dried Saraswati bed	Fatehabad, Haryana	R.S. Bisht, 1973-74
Rakhigarhi	Drishadvati / Chautang bed	Hisar, Haryana	Amarendra Nath; later Vasant Shinde
Ropar (Rupnagar)	Sutlej	Rupnagar, Punjab	Y.D. Sharma, 1953

Site	River	District / State	Excavated by
Surkotada	-	Kutch, Gujarat	J.P. Joshi
Sutkagendor	Dasht	Balochistan, Pakistan	Westernmost site
Alamgirpur	Hindon	Meerut, Uttar Pradesh	Easternmost site
Manda	Chenab	Jammu	Northernmost site
Daimabad	Pravara	Ahmednagar, Maharashtra	Southernmost site

Site - the one find it is famous for

Site	The famous find
Mohenjodaro	Great Bath, Great Granary, Pashupati seal, bronze Dancing Girl, steatite Priest-King, shell scale
Harappa	Cemetery R-37 and Cemetery H; two rows of six granaries with circular brick working-floors
Kalibangan	Earliest ploughed field in the subcontinent; seven fire altars; camel bones; bangle factory
Lothal	Dockyard; rice husk; Persian Gulf seal; double burial; bead factory; ivory scale
Dholavira	Three-part town; giant water reservoirs; the ten-sign 'signboard'
Chanhudaro	The only major city with no citadel; bead-makers' workshop; inkpot; lipstick
Banawali	Terracotta model of a plough; barley; radial street pattern
Rakhigarhi	Largest Harappan site found inside India
Ropar	First Harappan site excavated after independence; a dog buried with a human
Surkotada	The much-debated horse bones; pot burials
Daimabad	The bronze chariot group

- Rakhigarhi is in HISAR district, not Fatehabad - Fatehabad holds Banawali and Bhirrana.
- Banawali is in Haryana, not Gujarat, even though it always appears in a list beside Lothal, Dholavira and Surkotada.
- Kalibangan is the only Harappan site of Rajasthan that RPSC asks about by name; Baror in Sri Ganganagar and Sothi in Bikaner are the supporting

names.

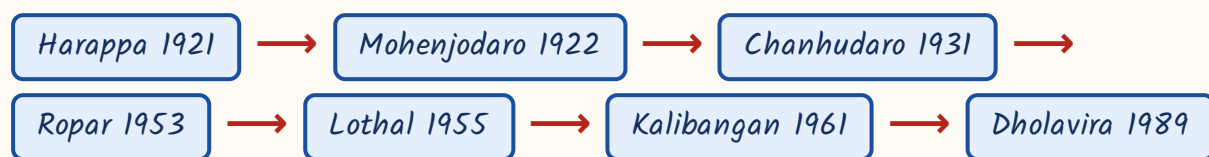
ASKED IN RAS

RAS Pre 2013 - the Harappan site of Kalibangan stands on the bank of which river? Answer: the Ghaggar. The same paper also ran a site-to-excavator matching set (Lothal - S.R. Rao, Harappa - Daya Ram Sahni, Dholavira - R.S. Bisht, Mohenjodaro - R.D. Banerji).

ASKED IN RAS

RAS Pre 2023 - Surkotada in Kutch, the site of the much-debated horse bones, was excavated by J.P. Joshi. The same year the paper asked who excavated Dholavira - R.S. Bisht.

Order of first excavation - asked as an ordering question



Kalibangan - do this one site twice as carefully

Kalibangan is your home site. It sits in Hanumangarh district on the left bank of the dried-up Ghaggar, which most scholars identify with the Vedic Saraswati. The name itself means black bangles, from the broken bangle pieces lying over the mounds. RPSC has asked its river, its district, its excavator and its finds, and it also slips Kalibangan into statement-based sets where all three statements are true.

- Excavated by B.B. Lal and B.K. Thapar between 1961 and 1969.
- Earliest evidence anywhere in the subcontinent of a ploughed agricultural field - furrows crossing at right angles, in the pre-Harappan level.

- A row of seven fire altars on a mud-brick platform in the citadel - evidence of ritual fire.
- Camel bones, and a bangle factory.
- Burials include an extended north-south burial, plus pot burials and symbolic burials.
- Kalibangan's lower town was also fortified, which is not true of most Harappan cities.
- The Kalibangan finds are displayed at the ASI's Archaeological Museum at Kalibangan itself.
- Fire altars are reported from three sites - Kalibangan, Lothal and Banawali - but the row of SEVEN on a platform, and the ploughed field, are Kalibangan alone.
- Do not hand Kalibangan the ten-sign signboard; that belongs to Dholavira.

ASKED IN RAS

RAS Pre 2021 - Kalibangan was excavated under the direction of B.B. Lal and B.K. Thapar. RPSC has also run the three-statement version: ploughed field, seven fire altars, Ghaggar-Saraswati - all three correct.

YAAD RAKHO

Kalibangan = KAL. K for Krishi (the ploughed field), A for Agni (the fire altars), L for Left bank of the Ghaggar. And the district begins with H - Hanumangarh.

Kalibangan vs Lothal - the two sites examiners deliberately mix

Kalibangan	Lothal
Hanumangarh, Rajasthan	Ahmedabad, Gujarat
Ghaggar (Saraswati)	Bhogavo
B.B. Lal and B.K. Thapar	S.R. Rao
Ploughed field, seven fire altars	Dockyard, rice husk, bead factory
Camel bones, bangle factory	Persian Gulf seal, ivory scale
Extended north-south burial	Double burial (man and woman together)

CURRENT LINK

Current link, as of September 2026 - Rakhigarhi has taken over as the headline Harappan dig. A PIB release of 22 June 2026 records that three complete skeletons and other skeletal fragments from Rakhigarhi were handed to the Anthropological Survey of India for ancient-DNA, isotopic and osteological study at its Kolkata laboratory; the 2025-26 season had opened eight burials on Mound 7. Rakhigarhi is described there as the largest known settlement of the Indus-Saraswati civilisation.

Town planning - the thing that made them a civilisation

What makes the Harappans remarkable is not any single building. It is the planning. Streets cut each other at right angles in a grid, the same grid at sites a thousand kilometres apart. The town splits in two - a raised citadel to the west for public buildings, and a lower town to the east where people lived. And the drains. Every Harappan city had covered brick drains running under the streets with manholes for cleaning and soak-pits at the end. No ancient civilisation matched that sanitation.

- Grid layout - streets and lanes crossing at right angles, dividing the town into rectangular blocks.

- Citadel on a raised mud-brick platform to the west; lower town, larger and lower, to the east.
- Burnt bricks in the fixed ratio 4:2:1 - length to breadth to thickness - across the whole civilisation.
- House doors opened on to side lanes, not on to the main street. Windows were few and small.
- Every house had a bathroom connected to the street drain; wells were common.
- Chanhudaro is the exception with no citadel; Dholavira is the exception with three parts instead of two - citadel, middle town and lower town.
- Keep the rivers straight - Mohenjodaro is on the Indus, Harappa on the Ravi. Examiners swap those two routinely.

The famous structures and where they are

Structure	Site	Point to remember
Great Bath	Mohenjodaro	About 11.88 x 7.01 m, 2.43 m deep, made watertight with bitumen; inside the citadel
Great Granary	Mohenjodaro	The largest single structure at the site
Granaries, two rows of six	Harappa	With circular brick working-floors near by
Dockyard	Lothal	Brick-built basin, connected to a river channel
Water reservoirs	Dholavira	The most elaborate water-harvesting system of any Harappan site

CURRENT LINK

Current link, as of September 2026 - Dholavira was inscribed on the UNESCO World Heritage List in 2021 and remains the only Harappan site of India on that list. Expect it in any 'Indian sites on the World Heritage list' question.

Seals, script, weights - the small objects that get asked

Seals are the signature object of this civilisation - more than two thousand of them. Most are square, made of steatite, and carry a line of picture-signs on top with an animal engraved below. They were probably used to stamp bales of goods. Understand that, then memorise the small facts.

- Material: mostly steatite. Shape: usually square, with a boss at the back.
- The unicorn - a one-horned animal - is by far the commonest device. The cow is absent.
- The Pashupati or proto-Shiva seal, from Mohenjodaro, shows a three-faced figure seated cross-legged among animals.
- The Persian Gulf seal from Lothal is the direct evidence for overseas trade.
- The script is pictographic and still undeciphered. It runs boustrophedon - the first line right to left, the next left to right.
- The longest inscription is the ten-sign 'signboard' at Dholavira.
- Weights are of chert, cubical, without markings. Binary in the lower denominations - 1, 2, 4, 8, 16, 32, 64 - and decimal above that.
- Measuring scales: an ivory scale from Lothal, a shell scale from Mohenjodaro.

TRAP

The Indus script is NOT deciphered, and it is NOT an early form of Sanskrit. Any statement that says otherwise is your wrong option. Also - the script is pictographic, not alphabetic.

CURRENT LINK

Current link, as of September 2026 - in early February 2025 the Tamil Nadu government announced a prize of one million US dollars for anyone who deciphers the Indus script. It is still unclaimed. Useful as a current-affairs peg for the plain fact that the script remains undeciphered.

Economy - farming, crafts, metals and trade

They were farmers first and traders second. Wheat and barley were the staples; the ploughed field at Kalibangan and the terracotta plough model at Banawali show how the fields were worked. Rice husk turns up at Lothal. And one first belongs to them alone - cotton.

- The Harappans were the first people in the world to produce cotton. The Greeks later called Indian cotton Sindon, after the Sindhu.
- Metals used: copper, bronze (copper plus tin), gold, silver and lead. Iron was completely unknown.
- Copper came mainly from Khetri in Rajasthan; the Aravalli belt supplied the metal.
- Craft evidence: bead factories at Lothal and Chanhudaro, a bangle factory at Kalibangan, shell working, faience, and pottery that is mostly wheel-made red ware with black painting.
- The bronze Dancing Girl was cast by the lost-wax (cire perdue) process, at Mohenjodaro. The bronze chariot group is from Daimabad.
- The domesticated animals include the humped bull, buffalo, sheep, goat, pig, dog, cat and elephant. The horse is the disputed one - only the Surkotada report claims it.

Trade names - a straight matching set

Name in Mesopotamian records	Region it means
Meluha	The Indus region itself
Dilmun	Bahrain
Magan	The Makran / Oman coast
Shortughai (Afghanistan)	Source of lapis lazuli

YAAD RAKHO

Trade route from far to near: Meluha - Magan - Dilmun - Mesopotamia. India, then Oman, then Bahrain, then Iraq. Learn it as a west-bound chain and the matching question solves itself.

TRAP

No iron. None. If any statement about Harappan metallurgy mentions iron tools from Mohenjodaro or Harappa, that statement is false - and RPSC has used exactly that statement inside a three-part set.

Religion and burial - and the temple question

We have no Harappan text, so religion is read off objects. Terracotta female figurines are taken as mother-goddess worship. The Pashupati seal is read as a proto-Shiva. Stone rings and cones are read as yoni and lingam worship. Trees, especially the pipal, and animals, especially the humped bull, appear again and again. And the swastika appears on seals.

- Objects of worship: mother goddess figurines, the proto-Shiva Pashupati seal, lingam-yni forms, the pipal tree, the humped bull, the swastika.
- No structure at any Harappan site has been positively identified as a temple. No large stone images of gods either.
- Fire altars are reported from Kalibangan, Lothal and Banawali.

- Burial types: Cemetery R-37 and Cemetery H at Harappa; extended north-south burial at Kalibangan; double burial at Lothal; pot burial at Surkotada; a dog buried with a human at Ropar.
- Statement sets love this pair - 'stone images of gods were installed in Harappan temples' is false; 'no structure has been positively identified as a temple' is true.

Decline - four theories, four names

The cities were abandoned by about 1900 BCE. Nobody knows why for certain, so the exam does not ask for the cause - it asks who proposed which theory. That is a pure matching question and you should never lose it.

Decline theory to scholar

Theory	Proposed by
Aryan invasion	Mortimer Wheeler
Recurrent floods	John Marshall, S.R. Rao, R.L. Raikes
Increasing aridity / climate change	Gurdip Singh
Tectonic disturbance	George F. Dales
Drying up of the Ghaggar-Saraswati	Widely held; explains the Rajasthan and Haryana abandonments

One more thing worth saying out loud. Decline did not mean disappearance. Late Harappan cultures continue - Cemetery H at Harappa, Rangpur in Gujarat, and in Rajasthan the Ghaggar valley settlements thin out and shift. What ends is the city, not the people.

REVISION RECAP

1. Harappa 1921 Daya Ram Sahni on the Ravi; Mohenjodaro 1922 R.D. Banerji on the Indus; both under John Marshall.
2. Mature phase c. 2600-1900 BCE; Bronze Age; largest in area of the early civilisations.
3. Kalibangan - Ghaggar, Hanumangarh, B.B. Lal and B.K. Thapar, ploughed field, seven fire altars, camel bones, bangle factory.
4. Lothal - Bhogavo, Ahmedabad, S.R. Rao, dockyard, rice husk, Persian Gulf seal, double burial, ivory scale.
5. Dholavira - Kutch, R.S. Bisht, three-part town, reservoirs, ten-sign signboard, UNESCO 2021.
6. Chanhudaro - no citadel; beads, inkpot, lipstick. Banawali - Fatehabad, terracotta plough. Rakhigarhi - Hisar, largest in India.
7. Ropar - Sutlej, Y.D. Sharma 1953, first dig after independence, dog buried with a human.
8. Boundary sites W-E-N-S: Sutkagendor, Alamgirpur, Manda, Daimabad.
9. Mehrgarh - Neolithic, earliest wheat, barley and cotton. Kot Diji and Amri - pre-Harappan. Bhirrana - earliest Hakra ware.
10. Grid streets, citadel west on a platform, lower town east, covered drains with manholes; bricks 4:2:1; doors on side lanes.
11. Great Bath 11.88 x 7.01 m, 2.43 m deep, bitumen-sealed, inside the Mohenjodaro citadel; Great Granary the largest structure there.
12. Seals steatite and square, unicorn commonest; script pictographic, undeciphered, boustrophedon.
13. Weights of chert, binary up to 64 then decimal; ivory scale Lothal, shell scale Mohenjodaro.
14. Metals copper, bronze, gold, silver, lead - iron unknown. First cotton in the world; Greek name Sindon.
15. Meluha = Indus, Dilmun = Bahrain, Magan = Makran/Oman, lapis lazuli from Shortughai.
16. Religion - mother goddess, Pashupati, lingam-yoni, pipal, humped bull, swastika; no temple identified anywhere.
17. Fire altars at three sites: Kalibangan, Lothal, Banawali.
18. Decline - Wheeler (invasion), Marshall/Rao/Raikes (floods), Gurdip Singh (aridity), Dales (tectonics), plus the drying Ghaggar.
19. Excavation order for the ordering question: Harappa, Mohenjodaro, Chanhudaro, Ropar, Lothal, Kalibangan, Dholavira.